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PSY 101: Introduction to Psychology - Mind, Behaviour and Evidence

What psychology actually studies, and how to evaluate a claim about behaviour

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Social Sciences
Psychology | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Psychology freshers arrive with strong intuitions and weak methods. This pack introduces the major perspectives, learning and memory, developmental and social psychology, and the research reasoning needed to tell evidence from anecdote.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish the biological, cognitive, behavioural, psychodynamic, humanistic and sociocultural perspectives.
- Explain classical and operant conditioning and observational learning with examples.
- Describe models of memory and reasons forgetting occurs.
- Evaluate a psychological claim using basic research-design criteria.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Perspectives and methods

Psychology is the scientific study of behaviour and mental processes, and it approaches questions from several angles.

- Biological: genes, brain structures and neurotransmitters.
- Cognitive: attention, perception, memory, language and problem solving.
- Behavioural: observable responses and consequences.
- Psychodynamic: unconscious conflict and early experience, historically influential but harder to test.
- Humanistic: growth, self-concept and personal agency.

- Sociocultural: how groups, culture and context shape behaviour.

> **Correlation is a clue, not a proof**
> A relationship between two variables does not establish direction or cause. Ask whether the study was experimental, randomised and controlled.

Learning and memory

Learning is a change in behaviour or knowledge resulting from experience; memory is the encoding, storage and retrieval of information.

- Classical conditioning: a neutral stimulus becomes associated with a meaningful one, as in Pavlov's dogs.
- Operant conditioning: behaviour is shaped by reinforcement and punishment.
- Observational learning: we learn by watching models, especially those we admire.
- Memory stages: sensory memory, short-term or working memory and long-term memory.
- Forgetting may result from encoding failure, decay, interference or retrieval failure.
- Spaced practice and retrieval practice are among the best-supported study techniques.

Development, personality and social behaviour

Human behaviour is shaped across the lifespan and in the presence of others.

- Piaget described cognitive stages; Vygotsky emphasised social scaffolding and the zone of proximal development.
- Erikson framed development as a sequence of psychosocial conflicts.
- Personality is described through traits; the Big Five model is widely used.
- Conformity, obedience and group influence can override individual judgement.
- Attribution explains how we assign causes to behaviour, often with bias in our own favour.
- Prejudice involves attitudes; discrimination involves behaviour.

Psychology as a science of behaviour and mind

Psychology studies behaviour and mental processes using empirical methods. Its authority comes from method, not from intuition: a claim about memory, emotion or personality must be testable and must survive attempts to falsify it. This is why psychology is a science subject with statistics in the curriculum, not a branch of philosophy.

The main perspectives each explain part of the picture. Biological approaches examine brain, genes and hormones. Cognitive approaches model attention, memory and problem-solving as information processing. Behavioural approaches study observable responses to environment. Psychodynamic approaches examine unconscious conflict. Humanistic approaches emphasise growth and meaning. Social approaches study how presence of others changes behaviour.

No single perspective explains everything, and a good answer uses more than one while stating what each leaves out.